

Entertainment Democracy

As politicians get transformed into art forms, a country fixated on Bollywood and cricket, celebrates the elevation of another spectacle

There was Lalu Prasad Yadav asking his cow who would win the vote of confidence—for the record, the sacred but silly animal picked the wrong hand. Here was Amar Singh deploying all his poetic skills—the UPA was in a bloom and would wipe out the Opposition with a broom. And yes, that was indeed L.K. Advani saying the Government was in the ICU. In the two-day television event that the vote of confidence became, ratcheting up the viewership of the otherwise somnolent Lok Sabha TV, the Bollywoodisation of Indian politics was complete. Both in the Lok Sabha and outside, politicians stuck to the film formula. There were vintage songs, delivered by the *nautanki* specialist Lalu; an angry young man speech flung at his detractors by Omar Abdullah; the unveiling of a bashful beauty in Rahul Gandhi (sorry about the gender but the Lok Sabha doesn't have enough women); and repeated assaults on the great patriarch (so what if Somnath Chatterjee looks like a giant teddy bear and sits on what looks like a *shaadi ki kursi*?). There was even the BJP rushing to the Speaker with a *kahaani mein* twist—their displaying of Rs 1 crore in the House being the equivalent of the bride's father yelling, "*nahin, yeh shaadi nahin ho sakti*". Add to that a cast of fringe spoilers (Ajit Singh, H.D. Deve Gowda, and N. Chandrababu Naidu) who would do any true Ram

AP PHOTO/MAHESH KUMAR A



NEW TRPs: The event had everyone glued to their TV sets

Gopal Varma underground noir proud, and it was a blockbuster that was made to order. So was it a hit or a flop? For those expecting politicians to have higher standards than the rest of this unsettling country, the tele-event was a flop. For those who know that we now live in a performance culture, where each individual is an art form, the drama had everything that was over-the-top, across-the-broad, and beyond-belief. The joker in the new Batman, *The Dark Knight*, asks all his victims-to-be: "Why so serious?" Our politicians obliged by making laughing stocks of themselves. Mayawati declared with complete confidence that USA was going to attack Iran while K. Yerran Naidu was convinced that Manmohan Singh had sold India to "The Bush". Is it any wonder that Lalu is a regular on television reality shows, especially when they require a little help with the TRPs? And that Omar Abdullah is playing himself in a new release this week? With our actors increasingly behaving like politicians (the number of camps in Bollywood beats the number of political parties) and actor MPs having nothing to say (it was a surprise Govinda turned up at all), it's a good swap. About time television rating points got converted into television-rated politicians.

by Kaveree Bamzai



of notes alleging horse-trading by Congress and the sp. Even as the three MPs hurled charges at Ahmed Patel and Amar Singh, the Congress core team took charge. As the House adjourned, two teams were put to work. One was engaged in damage control in the media engaging those who had done the sting while the other team ensured that the trust vote was not delayed. The BJP, by then realised, it had been outwitted.

The trust vote saw Sonia in full control. It was almost as if her seat was the control console in the final hours of the trust vote. It was pre-arranged that those shy to press the "wrong" buttons in the presence of their party colleagues would not use the electronic voting system. They would use the voting slips and vote in the lobby. That plan too was not without drama. Just before the vote, TDP MPs—D.K. Audikesavulu and M. Jagannath—bagged by Reddy to vote for UPA got cold feet. While Jagannath managed to use the electronic voting machine, Audikesavulu was cornered by Yerran Naidu. Abdullah and another ally, AIMM leader Asaduddin Owaisi, who spotted this and signalled Sonia. She then despatched two Andhra Congress MPs.